

Radical Orthodox theologians have certainly left themselves exposed, but which a more nuanced introduction might have helped overcome.

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Matthew Levering, *Participatory Biblical Exegesis: A Theology of Biblical Interpretation*. Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 2008, xi + 310pp. \$25.00

With *Participatory Biblical Exegesis*, Matthew Levering, associate professor of theology at Ave Maria University, has produced a remarkable book. It is a provocative and substantial contribution to two discourses: first, the contemporary systematic discussion of theologies of participation and 'deification'; second, the emerging discourse of the 'theological interpretation of Scripture' – a discourse seeking to recover ways of reading the Bible that lead to knowledge of the Triune God and occur from a distinctly ecclesial location. The fact that Levering forges a close connection between these two discourses is, in itself, an accomplishment. Some discussions of participation and deification seem to treat biblical exegesis as an afterthought. On the other hand, some accounts of theological hermeneutics are extremely shy about making significant doctrinal claims beyond retrieving a construal of the 'rule of faith'. Levering connects and intertwines these two discourses as he sets forth an argument claiming that a theology of participation is a necessary component of a Christian theology of scriptural interpretation.

Levering's central thesis is stated in a succinct yet dense form: 'The chapters of this book advance the proposal that Christian biblical exegesis, in accord with the Christian and biblical understanding of reality, should envision history not only as a linear unfolding of individual moments, but also as an ongoing participation in God's active providence, both metaphysically and Christologically-pneumatologically' (p. 1). Key to Levering's proposal is his construal of two dimensions of history: a 'linear' dimension, and a 'participatory' dimension. In one sense, modern historical-critical studies of Scripture pay proper attention to the 'linear' history – the messy flow of history which led to the composition of the biblical texts in their various ancient contexts. But for Christian interpreters, there is also a 'participatory' aspect of history: that Scripture is the means that the Spirit uses to testify to Jesus Christ and shape persons into Christ's likeness ('Christological-pneumatological'), and that history itself participates metaphysically in the Triune God's providential work.

Having made the distinctions between linear and participatory dimensions of history, Levering goes on to argue that the two dimensions cannot simply co-exist side by side without influencing the other. Indeed, while readers should attend to the 'linear' flow of history, we should avoid seeing this 'linear flow' as autonomous from God's providential acts. In contrast to the modern tendency to equate 'historical

exegesis' with exegesis in 'its original context', Levering argues that 'there is no "original context" whose integrity requires, even temporarily, exegetical neutrality as regards the fullness of the participatory dimensions' (p. 12). 'History' is richer than what historical-critical tools alone can access, because history itself participates in God's providential work. This does not annihilate linear history, but it means that 'the participatory indwells the linear' (p. 13).

The key for holding together these two dimensions of history lies in Christology. Levering not only gives a christological exposition of his approach, but roots it exegetically in an examination of Aquinas's interpretation of John 3:27–36. Working from the language of John's Gospel, Levering argues that 'Jesus Christ constitutes the center of linear and participatory history as the incarnate Word, the one Mediator, in whom human beings receive the Holy Spirit and are led to the Father' (p. 33). As such, exegetical approaches which read the Old Testament in light of Jesus Christ can be 'historical' in the most robust sense of the term. They refuse to treat Israelite history as autonomous – a reality sufficient in itself – when it is a reality that participates in God made known in Christ. Historical interpretation of Scripture which consistently spurns doctrinal categories is, in fact, insufficiently historical.

Levering then gives a case study of the way in which John 3:27–36 was interpreted in late medieval, Renaissance and early modern contexts – tracing the gradual separation of linear and participatory approaches to history, and with it, the separation of biblical studies from doctrine. Levering's focus upon the reception-history of a particular passage is a valuable tool in this attempt to trace a trajectory. While Levering's account does not provide a comprehensive reception-history for these periods, it does give enough historical detail to display a gradual separation of linear and participatory approaches to history. At the end of this section, Levering provides a thoughtful and incisive critique of the operative view of history in Raymond Brown's biblical work. Levering does not descend to polemics, or minimize Brown's significant scholarly achievements. But he does point to some very particular ways in which the participatory dimension of history has been neglected in Brown's work.

One of the most theologically rich sections of Levering's book is a chapter on 'Participatory Biblical Exegesis and God the Teacher'. Here, he gives a theological rationale for *integrating* 'linear-historical' and 'participatory-historical' modes of biblical interpretation 'into an interpretive, ecclesial, and performative engagement with *sacra doctrina*, in which the goal is learning the triune Teacher – learning the Love of the Word of the Father' (p. 82). Levering weaves together a trinitarian theology of revelation with the notion that scriptural interpretation involves a participation in God. Because of sin, we cannot teach ourselves to know and love God and neighbor through Scripture. God must be the Teacher. Thus, 'understanding the texts of Scripture in themselves is not, in itself, the purpose of reading scripture'. Instead, the purpose of reading Scripture is to encounter Jesus Christ and be 'caught up into Love's wise pattern for our lives' as those who are in communion with Christ in the church (p. 67).

As Levering develops his argument, he is open about his ecclesial location as a Roman Catholic thinker, and he makes use of this location in some very positive ways. On the one hand, many of the engagements and criticisms are with other Catholic authors – thus the critique of Raymond Brown, as well as a critique of Karl Rahner's operative theology of history, in contrast to Henri de Lubac, whose thought Levering seeks to extend. But Levering is not shy about either affirming or criticizing other Christian authors as well. Levering draws appreciatively upon the work of John Webster, while parting ways at points related to ecclesiology. Overall, *Participatory Biblical Exegesis* is ecumenical in the best sense of the term: it draws deeply upon Scripture, as well as on the shared and distinct traditions of the author's ecclesial location. It is honest about areas of difference. But Levering also shows that drawing deeply upon one's distinct theological tradition can illumine areas of ecumenical commonality, and not simply difference.

Participatory Biblical Exegesis does have a peculiarity in format that some readers will find helpful, but others will find frustrating. The body of the book is just 148 pages; this is followed by 113 pages of explanatory endnotes in a smaller font. In some ways, this format allows the book to function on two levels: first, the presentation of Levering's constructive argument in the body of the book; second, a wide-ranging survey and engagement of the scholarly literature in the endnotes. The endnotes are not just explanatory, but often analytical. For example, Levering has an appreciative yet critical engagement with the work of N.T. Wright which takes place almost entirely in the endnotes. Some readers will be relieved that their reading of Levering's central argument will not be interrupted by various digressions. Others will have difficulty following two parallel yet quite distinct types of discourse between the body and the endnotes.

In terms of the book's overall argument, probably the weakest link is Levering's dependence upon a genealogy of the breakdown of a participatory metaphysic rooted in a critique of late medieval nominalism. Genealogies are often elusive, and historical theologies have called this genealogy into serious question as it has been used by the theologians of Radical Orthodoxy. However, Levering's argument is not, ultimately, dependent upon that particular genealogy. Moreover, he moves in a promising direction in his concrete attempt to discern the dynamics of the separation of biblical studies and doctrine in his history of the exegesis of John 3:27–36. More studies will be needed to further explore the complex dynamics of this separation. But Levering is asking the right questions: his probing of the operative theologies of 'history' among biblical interpreters points to a key area for biblical scholars and theologians to analyze. All too often, debates about biblical interpretation are reduced to a debate about whether an interpretation is sufficiently 'historical' in its approach. But there are different operative ontologies and theologies of history that can be brought to Scripture, and so the question of history should be the beginning of a conversation, not the end of it.

In the end, Levering's book provides a provocative and helpful contribution to both the discourse on the theological interpretation of Scripture, and systematic theologies of participation. It is to be highly recommended to systematic theologians

and biblical scholars who seek to read the Bible not simply as a source for reconstructing ancient history, but as Holy Scripture.

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Paul D. Molnar, *Incarnation and Resurrection: Toward a Contemporary Understanding*. Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2007, xiv + 418pp. \$35.00 / £19.99

Paul Molnar stands out in his concern for the connections between theological loci and the necessity of their proper ordering for the integrity of Christian doctrine. Here his concern is for the connection between the doctrines of the incarnation and resurrection, and its significance for the doctrine of the Trinity, soteriology and ethics. Jesus' identity as the Word of God incarnate and Saviour is disclosed in the resurrection, and the objectivity of the resurrection and our justification is rooted in Christ's prior identity as the Word incarnate. The integrity of understandings of divine freedom and ethics grounded in God's grace hang on this articulation. Unless the risen incarnate Lord determines Christian theology, it loses its Christian character. Molnar develops this striking thesis through close reading of a number of modern theologians using David Fergusson's typology of modern interpretations of the resurrection: radical (the resurrection is the rise of faith in the disciples); liberal (the resurrection is realized through the disciples' faith); and traditional (the resurrection was an event in the life of Jesus that gave rise to the disciples' faith).

Karl Barth exemplifies the last view. Here Christ's resurrection reveals the covenant between God and man achieved in the incarnation as it culminates in Christ's passion. Thus the resurrection has to be an objective event unlike any other event: the very revelation of the presence of the eternal in time for us through the forty days of the resurrection appearances. Hence it is unintelligible without the doctrine of the incarnation to which it points, and thereby that of the immanent Trinity, which alone allows us to understand the resurrection as the revelation of God in his acts and not the projection of our humanity.

Thus understood, the resurrection is decisive for every part of Barth's theology. It constrains Barth to recognize Christ's uniqueness in his humanity in the mode of God, so determining our knowledge of God. Since in the resurrection God answers Jesus' obedience unto death and judgement, whereby sin is destroyed, *and* discloses Jesus' divine-human identity, the atonement must be seen as an act of free, sovereign mercy grounded in the Son's eternal existence. By the same token, the risen Lord determines the content and possibility (by the Spirit) of our faith, and must be the starting point of theology: there can be no going behind the New Testament's witness to an event that includes and exceeds history and